

POSC 3710: European Politics

9/16/2026: THE EUROPEAN UNION: (HOW) DOES IT WORK?

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Two more German states vote on Sunday

MECKLENBURG-VORPOMMERN

The SPD's last eastern stronghold

- Minister-President Manuela Schwesig (SPD) has governed since 2017, since 2021 in coalition with the Left. In 2021 the SPD took nearly 40%
- Last poll: AfD 35, SPD 32, Left 11, CDU 8
- Watch: can the SPD and the Left keep their majority,
- What happens if the AfD finishes first?

BERLIN

Five parties within nine points

- Governing Mayor Kai Wegner (CDU) has led a CDU-SPD coalition since 2023. He withdrew as candidate in July, after criticism of his handling of January's multi-day blackout; Finance Senator Stefan Evers leads the CDU
- Last poll (Infratest dimap, 7-9 September): Left 21, CDU 20, AfD 18, Greens 16, SPD 12
- The Left's candidate is Elif Eralp; the AfD's is Kristin Brinker
- Watch: Who gets the first chance to form a government? Will the SPD work with the Left?

Canada to “Join” the EU?



Ursula von der Leyen, the president of the European Commission, and Prime Minister Mark Carney of Canada at the European Parliament in Strasbourg, France, on Wednesday. Yves Herman/Reuters

The State of the (European) Union, Strasbourg, this morning

What she announced

1. The 2028–34 budget “needs new own resources”: EU-level revenue, on top of what the 27 governments pay in
2. “Europe’s own Article 4”: one state triggers it, all 27 convene. A Security Council with the UK, Norway, Canada and Ukraine
3. After Ceuta (70,000 migrants crossed from Morocco in July): a European Emergency Response Framework. “Ceuta is Spain. Ceuta is Europe”
4. EU Kids Act, proposed tomorrow: no social media under 13, no personal account under 15. Platforms must prove they are safe

THE SPEECH

The Commission sets its program

- Commission President Ursula von der Leyen (Germany) addresses the European Parliament every September, then debates its members. The first was in 2010
- It sets the Commission’s legislative program for the year, as an American president’s address does. The Parliament approved her; voters did not elect her
- This year’s questions: the 2028–2034 budget, defense, enlargement, trade with China, the cost of living
- What does she ask for from EU member states? What does she offer?

Quite literally 0 mentions of the USA, which is a bit odd

Who runs the EU these days?

URSULA VON DER LEYEN

President of the European Commission, since 2019

Germany. Former German defense minister. Proposes EU laws and runs the civil service. Won a second term in 2024

ANTÓNIO COSTA

President of the European Council, since 2024

Portugal. Prime minister of Portugal, 2015–24. Chairs the summits of the 27 heads of government

ROBERTA METSOLA

President of the European Parliament, since 2022

Malta. Leads the 720-member chamber, the only EU body that voters choose directly

KAJA KALLAS

High Representative for Foreign Affairs, since 2024

Estonia. Prime minister of Estonia, 2021–24. Speaks for the EU abroad.

MICHEÁL MARTIN

Taoiseach of Ireland; Council presidency, July–December 2026

Ireland chairs the ministers' meetings for six months and is brokering the 2028–2034 budget

CHRISTINE LAGARDE

President of the European Central Bank, since 2019

France. Former French finance minister and head of the IMF. Sets interest rates for the 21 euro countries

Where We Left Off

- 9/2: France and Germany pooled coal and steel to allow economic recovery *and to make another war nearly impossible*
- 9/9: nations are often modern and perhaps “Imagined”.
- Last Time: the Christian democrats designed European integration; the social democrats came round to it
- Today: What kind of supranational organization did the European nation-states build?. What it is, how it decides, whether it is democratic

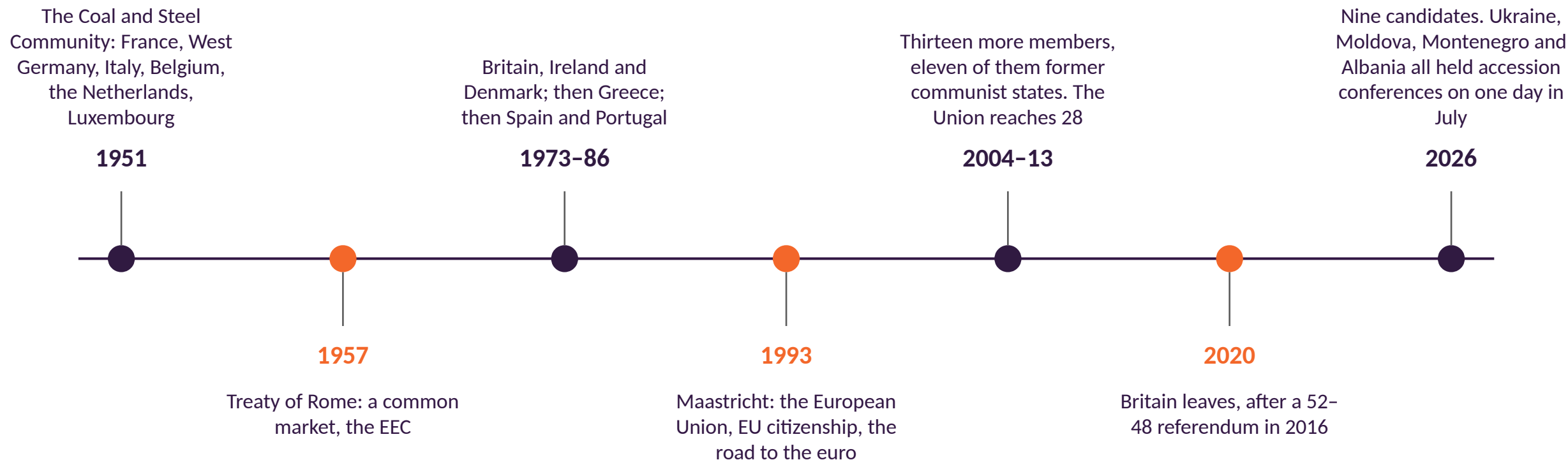
Opening Discussion

- South Carolina cannot leave the United States (although, it tried once). Britain left the EU with a democratic vote. Which arrangement would you rather live under?
- Suppose the fifty governors met in Washington to write federal law, and Congress could only amend it. How would we evaluate that in terms of democracy?
- What would you hand to a body above your own government in return for one market, one currency and free movement? Is this appealing at all? Why is it appealing to (some) Europeans?

What the EU Is

- **It's enormous:** 27 states, about 450 million people, bound by treaties that can only be changed through consensus
- A customs union + a single market: goods, services, money and people move freely
- 21 members share a currency; 25 have abolished passport checks between them
- Its own parliament, court, budget and civil service. No standing army, no police, almost no taxes
- “A unique political and economic partnership”

From six members to twenty-seven, 1951-2026



Joining takes the unanimous consent of the existing members and usually a decade + of negotiation; Turkey has been a candidate since 1999.

The Union, the euro and Schengen all have different members

THE UNION: 27

Single market, court, parliament

- All members are in the single market and the customs union, and under the Court of Justice
- Enlargement and treaty change need all 27
- Left: Britain, in 2020. Waiting: nine candidates

THE EURO: 21

Six members keep their own currency

- Denmark negotiated an opt-out in 1992; Sweden voted no in 2003
- Poland, Czechia, Hungary and Romania have not joined the Euro. Bulgaria did, on 1 January 2026
- The European Central Bank in Frankfurt sets one interest rate for all 21
 - This has created problems...

SCHENGEN: 29

No passport checks, four non-members included

- 25 EU states plus Norway, Iceland, Switzerland and Liechtenstein
- Ireland stays out to keep its open border with Britain. Cyprus is waiting for the other 25 to vote it in
- Any member can restore checks for a while. Germany did so in 2024

Is it really above the State?

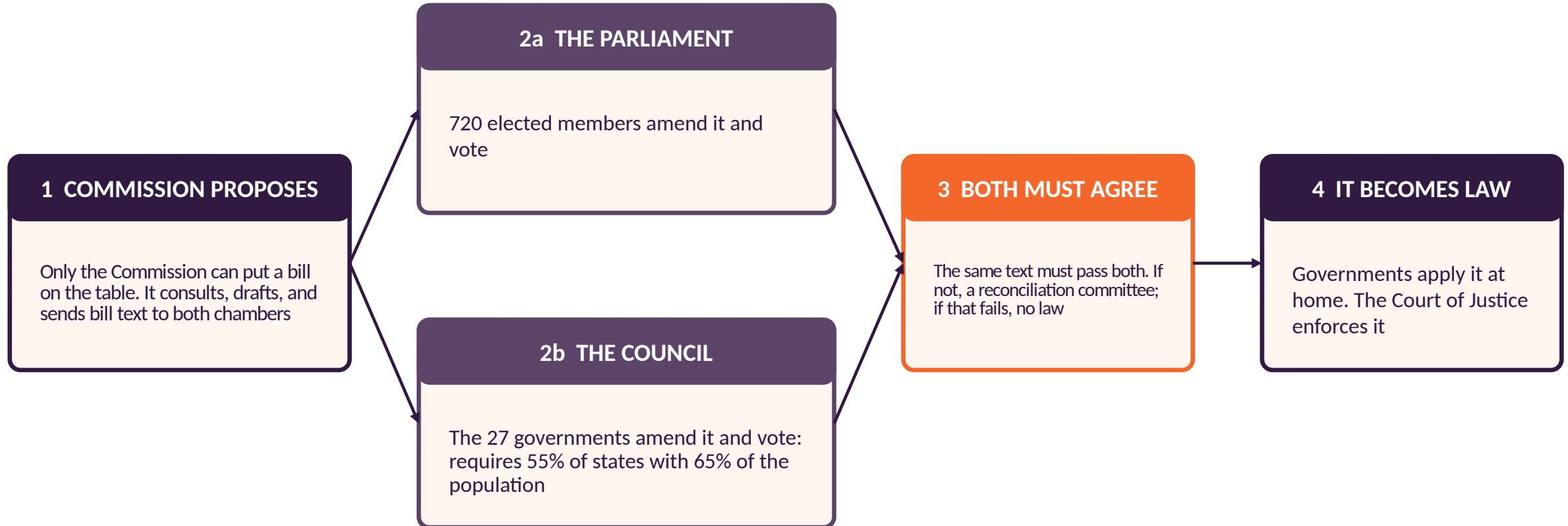
- Supranational: above the states. A member is bound to decisions even if it votes no. The Commission, Parliament, Court and Central Bank
- Intergovernmental: between governments. Every state keeps a veto. The European Council, and the Council on tax, foreign policy and new members
- Most laws now pass by qualified majority: 55% of the states, holding 65% of the population
 - Leads to the question we take up later today – is the EU democratic?

Five institutions: Who are they and what do they do?

	WHO	HOW THEY GET THERE	WHAT IT DOES
European Commission	27 commissioners, one per state, under President von der Leyen	Nominated by the governments, approved by the Parliament, five-year term	Proposes EU law, enforces the treaties, negotiates trade deals
Council of the EU	The 27 governments' ministers	Elected at home. The chair rotates every six months; currently Ireland	Amends and adopts laws with the Parliament. Requires unanimity on tax, foreign policy, new members
European Parliament	720 members in eight cross-national groups, under President Metsola	Elected directly every five years by proportional representation; most recently in June 2024	Amends and adopts most laws with the Council; approves the Commission and the budget
European Council	The 27 heads of government, chaired by President Costa	Elected at home; meets at least four times a year	Sets direction and settles the big issues: budget, treaties, enlargement. Passes no laws
Court of Justice	27 judges, one per state, in Luxembourg	Appointed by the governments for six-year terms	Binding rulings. EU law > National law when they conflict

A sixth is the European Central Bank in Frankfurt, which sets interest rates for the euro and is nominally independent of politics (like the US fed).

How a bill becomes a law, EU Edition



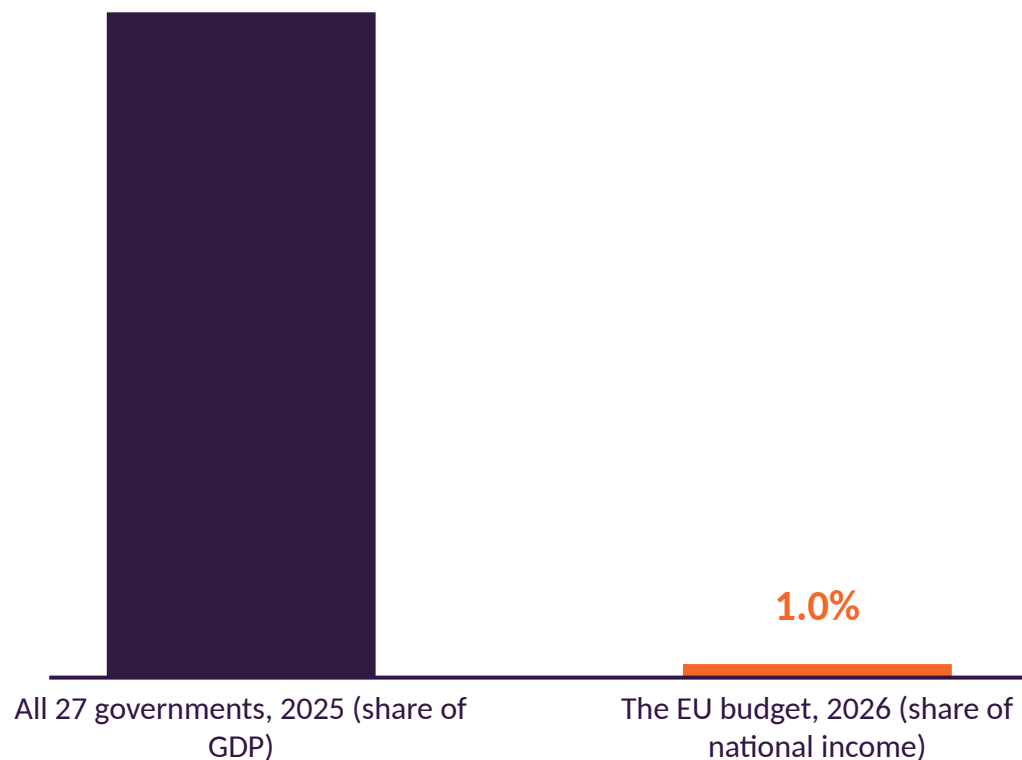
What the EU Does Not Do

- It does not tax.
 - Its budget is 1% of the Union's income; raising the ceiling needs all 27 states to approve
- It does not run the welfare state, schools, hospitals, police or armies.
- National officials apply EU rules.
 - EU employs fewer people than a mid-sized city
- Its focus is cross-border economics: trade, competition, the single market, the euro
- Moravcsik: the EU does the tasks that democracies everywhere hand to experts

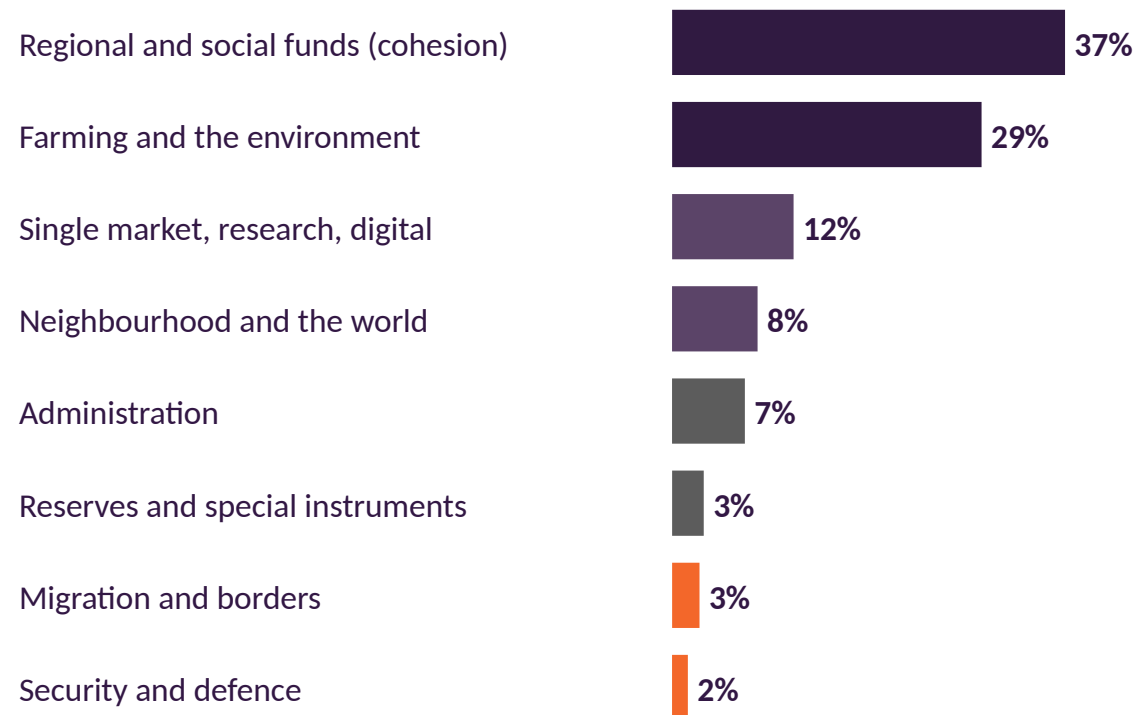
How much does the EU Spend?

Public spending, share of national income

49.5%

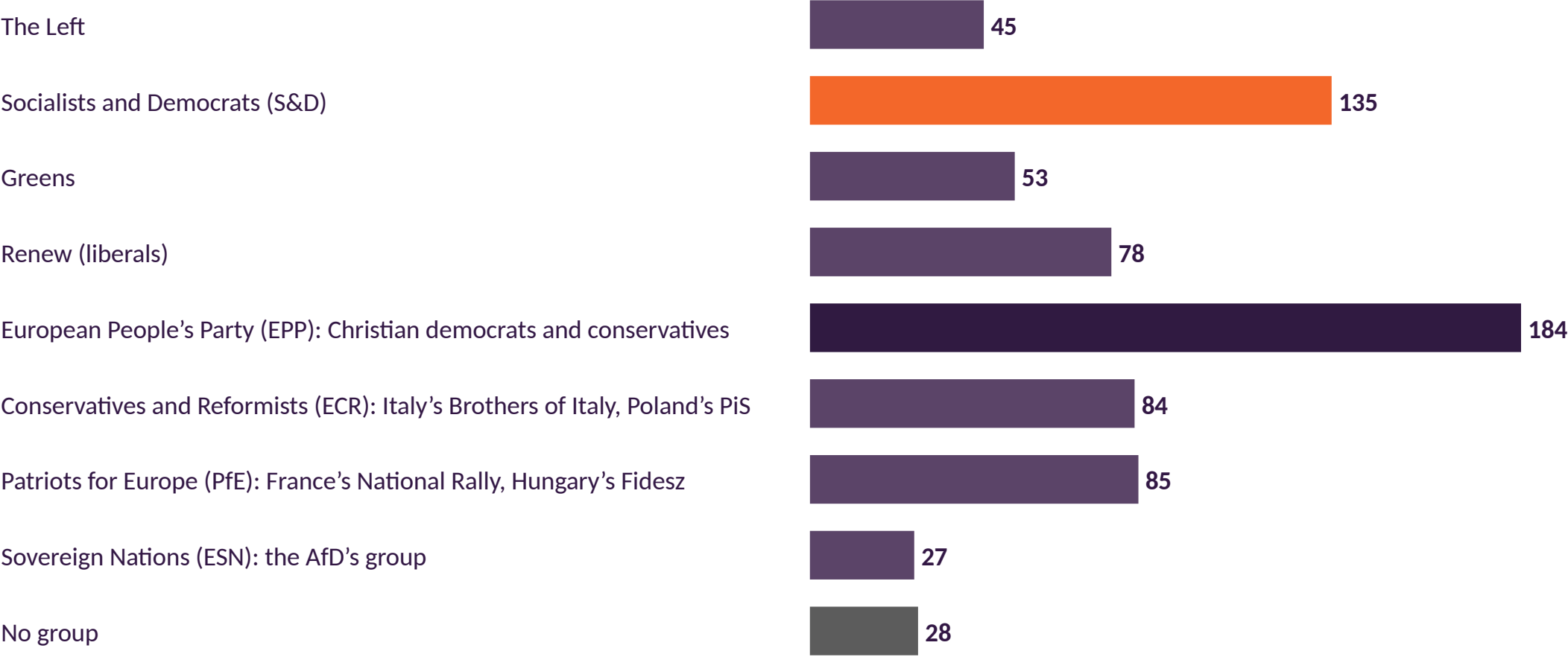


Where the EU's €193 billion goes, 2026



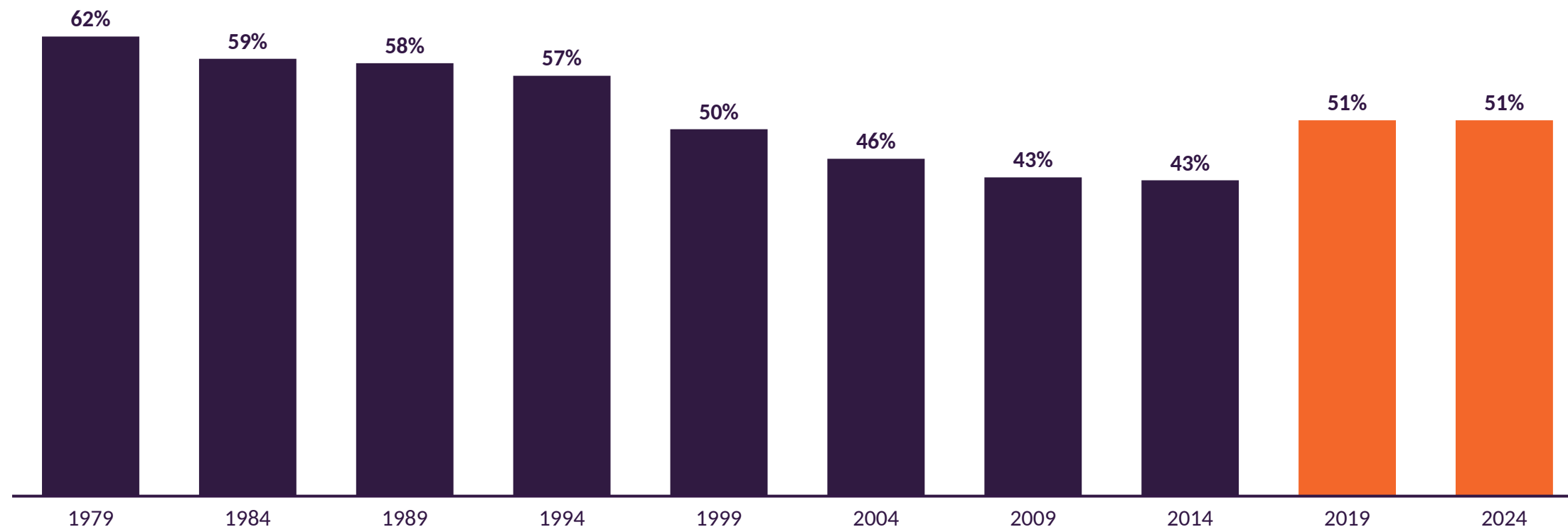
Council of the EU (2026 budget, €192.8bn in commitments); Eurostat (government expenditure, 2025). About one euro in fifty of public money in Europe is spent through Brussels. The 2028–34 budget is being negotiated now: the Commission asked for about €1.8 trillion over seven years; Germany wants €400 billion less.

The European Parliament, 720 seats, September 2026



European Parliament, July 2026; one seat vacant. The two families of Monday, EPP and S&D, are still the two largest groups and hold 44% of the seats between them; the three groups to their right hold 27%. Members vote by group, not by country: a French socialist usually votes with a German one.

Turnout in European Parliament elections, 1979–2024



European Parliament, EU-wide turnout. Follesdal and Hix call these 'second-order national contests': contested by national parties on national issues, with governing parties losing. Turnout fell for thirty-five years and recovered in 2019 and 2024, as Europe itself became a source of conflict

(Is there a)The Democratic Deficit?

- Power moves to executive: ministers in Brussels escape their own parliaments
- The European Parliament is weak: it cannot propose a law or choose a government
- European elections are “second order”: they depend on national issues
- The EU is too distant and too strange to understand, voters cannot judge it
- Policy drifts from what majorities want: deregulation, tight monetary policy, farm subsidies

A Defense of the EU

- Critics measure the EU against an ideal democracy.
 - Against real ones, it looks normal. We have farm subsidies, tight fiscal policy and deregulation here too!
- Not a superstate: narrow mandate, no tax power, unanimity for treaties, supermajorities for laws
- Democratically accountable : elected Parliament **and** the elected governments in the Council
- Its insulated parts, central bank, court, regulators, are insulated at home too,
- Voters ignore EU elections because health, schools, pensions and taxes are national. National elections *matter more to voters lives*

Moravcsik vs Follesdal and Hix

“Constitutional checks and balances, indirect democratic control via national governments, and the increasing powers of the European Parliament are sufficient to ensure that EU policy-making is, in nearly all cases, clean, transparent, effective and politically responsive to the demands of European citizens.”

Moravcsik, p. 605

“The EU may be more ‘representative’ precisely because it is, in a narrow sense, less ‘democratic’.”

Moravcsik, p. 614

(Is there such a thing as ‘too democratic’?)

Contestation for political leadership “is ultimately the difference between a democracy and an enlightened form of benevolent authoritarianism, is an essential element of even the ‘thinnest’ theories of democracy, yet is conspicuously absent in the EU.”

Follesdal & Hix, p. 534

The Debate

MORAVCSIK (2002)

FOLLESDAL AND HIX (2006)

The standard

Real democracies, in a multi-level system

Democracy requires contestation for power

What the EU does

Regulates cross-border markets: low-salience, expert work

Makes choices with winners and losers: budgets, trade, labour rules

Accountability

Through the elected governments in the Council, plus the Parliament

Nowhere: no one can be voted out for an EU policy

Why voters don't care

The issues are not salient to them

Nothing is contested, so nothing is salient

Insulation

Normal and justified: courts, central banks, regulators

Fine for technical choices; wrong for distributive ones

The remedy

None. More participation would backfire

A contest for the Commission presidency; an open Council

Twenty Years Later

- 2014: parties named lead candidates; Luxembourg's former premier Jean-Claude Juncker won and got the job
- Europe is now fought over in national elections: Brexit, France's National Rally, the AfD
 - UK shows that it is possible to hold the EU accountable through threat of exit
- Follesdal and Hix got part of their wish. Did it make the EU more democratic?

What Europeans say about the Union, spring 2026



Standard Eurobarometer 105, fieldwork 12 March to 5 April 2026, all 27 states. Trust in the EU is at a high, and since the 2010s it has run above trust in national governments. Moravcsik predicted the pattern in 2002: insulated institutions are often more popular than legislatures.

A European Nation?

- Gellner: one culture, one state. The EU runs in 24 official languages, contains even more distinct cultures
- Anderson: imagined through shared symbols. The EU has: flag, anthem, holiday, passport, euro
- Three in four feel like EU citizens, but most still put their nationality first
- Nations were made by schools, conscription and railways. The EU doesn't control these, and member states have no incentive to foster an EU identity

Above and Below

- Nation-states are squeezed from above (the EU) and below (nations without states)
- Scotland and Catalonia want independence inside the EU; the single market makes a small state viable
- Regions deal with Brussels directly: offices, funds, a committee of their own
- Brussels is cautious: a new state must apply to join, and Spain's veto is waiting
- Which is it: a release valve inside old states, or an exit door?

Discussion

- Is the EU democratic? How can we decide?
- The Commission proposes; two elected bodies decide. More or less democratic than an executive order?
- Nine countries are waiting to join. What makes the EU so attractive?
- The FRC is an EU member. Think about which of today's arguments will you use when an accession vote reaches your parliament?

Where We Go Next

- Next: the welfare state. Why Europe's states spend half of everything, while the EU spends one per cent
- Case Study: health care systems.
- Then: can the welfare state survive?
- ~11/18: the EU under strain. Brexit ten years later, enlargement, rearmament

The Federal Republic of Clemson

- The FRC is a member state. On 11/18 your parliament votes on a new member's accession and on the FRC's contribution to European defense
- Your manifesto has a Europe section: enlargement, defence, the United States and Russia. Two of the six parties are EU-critical, from opposite ends of the spectrum
- Manifesto due Wednesday 9/30, ~2,000 words
- Next: the welfare state